Aquifer Open Study Notes

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1 Timothy

1 Timothy 1:1

- our Savior: Here this refers to God, but also equally applies to Christ Jesus (1:15; 2:3–4; see 2 Timothy 1:9–10; Titus 1:3–4; 2:10, 13).
- our hope: True hope is based on God, not other human hopes such as wealth (1 Timothy 4:10; 5:5; 6:17).

1 Timothy 1:1–2

This opening includes the usual parts of a letter:

- sender,
- recipient, and
- greeting.

Additional details emphasize Paul's important message (see also Romans 1:1–7; 1 Corinthians 1:1–3; Galatians 1:1–5; Titus 1:1–4).

1 Timothy 1:2

- Timothy was in Ephesus as Paul's representative (see 1 Timothy Book Introduction, "Setting").
- my true child: Timothy was like a true child to Paul in the faith (see Philippians 2:20; compare Titus 1:4). But he was probably not directly converted by Paul (see Acts 16:1).

1 Timothy 1:3

not to teach false doctrines: As Paul had warned before, false teachers entered the church in Ephesus (Acts 20:29–31). He wrote this letter to help Timothy deal with them.

1 Timothy 1:3–11

Paul's greetings usually include a mention of thanks or blessing to God. Greco-Roman letters were often structured this way. First Timothy and Titus probably do not include this because they are official letters authorizing a delegate (see 1 Timothy Book Introduction, "Literary Genre"). Instead, Paul first addresses his concern about stopping false teachers.

1 Timothy 1:4

- myths and endless genealogies ... speculation: Paul might be dismissing their teachings as not significant, or he might rejecting their interpretations and their justification of bad behavior (1:7; see also 2 Timothy 4:3–4; Titus 1:14; 3:9; 2 Peter 1:16; 1 Timothy 1:8–11; 4:1–2, 7; see also Titus 1:15–16).
- endless genealogies: In Judaism, a genealogy (list of ancestors) established a person's spiritual heritage. The false teachers might have focused too much on this. They probably also used Old Testament genealogies in imaginary interpretations of the law (Genesis 2–4; 5:1–32).
- rather than the stewardship of God's work, which is by faith: The Greek uses an important word ("stewardship," "household management") connected to managing a household (see 1 Timothy 3:15). This phrase can also imply other meanings, including faithfulness to God's household management or faithfulness in managing God's household.

1 Timothy 1:5

- The goal of our instruction: Paul intends to encourage a life committed to God that comes from sincere faith and spiritual renewal (see Titus 3:5; see also 1 Corinthians 13:1–13; Colossians 3:14).
- In 1 Timothy and Titus, references to a clear conscience contrast with the false teachers' dead consciences (for example, 1 Timothy 1:19; 4:2; Titus 1:15).

1 Timothy 1:6

- Some: This might be a way of classifying the false teachers as general opponents of the good news about Jesus (see Romans 3:8; 1 Corinthians 4:18; 2 Corinthians 3:1; Galatians 1:7).
- They claimed to be Christians but missed the main message of the good news about Jesus and turned away.

1 Timothy 1:6–11

Paul now explains the false teachers' ideas and uses their own topics against them.

1 Timothy 1:7

They wanted to teach the law of Moses, but this desire showed the irony of their thoughts in contrast to their actions. They did not interpret the law very well according to the good news about Jesus. They neither understood nor followed the law (see 1:8–11).

1 Timothy 1:9

law is not enacted for the righteous: Generally, people who have virtue do not need laws. For Christians, living right with God comes from faith in Christ, not from obeying the law (see Galatians 5:16–26; Ephesians 2:11–14; Titus 2:11–14; compare Romans 8:1–17; James 2:14–16).

1 Timothy 1:10

- This list shows the main ideas of the false teachers' teachings and their spiritual condition. It also demonstrates how superior the good news is over the law (see Matthew 5:20; Galatians 5:22–23).
- who is averse to sound teaching: See also 1 Timothy 6:3–4; 2 Timothy 1:13; 4:3; Titus 1:9, 13; 2:1, 8. This addition to the list is both a final summary and a strong statement. The good news about Jesus now defines what makes a person right with God more effectively than the law. But the law still addresses anything that opposes the gospel. The false teachers focused on the law, emphasizing their rejection of Paul's teaching.

1 Timothy 1:11

Titus 2:11–14 provides a more detailed explanation Paul's idea in this verse.

1 Timothy 1:12–17

I thank Christ Jesus our Lord: This expression of thanks is a side note from Paul's message to Timothy (1:3–11, 18–20). Paul's role in proclaiming the good news about Jesus prompts gratitude and shows why he is thankful (1:11). It also serves as a model for readers. When discussing his work, Paul gives credit to God and makes it evident he is doing God's work (see also 2 Corinthians 1:21–22; 2:14–17; 3:4–6; 4:7; 12:9–10).

1 Timothy 1:15

This is a trustworthy saying: This phrase appears only in the letters to Timothy and Titus (1 Timothy 3:1; 4:8–9; 2 Timothy 2:11–13; Titus 3:4–8). These sayings are probably quotes from tradition that Paul has adapted for the current situation. The saying emphasizes the mercy shown to Paul, but it also offers correction to the false teachers. The saying emphasizes Christ's arrival in history to save sinners.

This saying was probably being suppressed in some way by the false teachers, who focused on:

- law (1 Timothy 1:7),
- special knowledge (6:20; see also Titus 1:16), and
- rules like those in 1 Timothy 4:3 (see also Colossians 2:16–23).

1 Timothy 1:18

the previous prophecies about you: This probably happened during Timothy's commissioning as a leader (ordination) (see 4:14; 2 Timothy 1:6; compare Acts 13:2–3).

1 Timothy 1:18–20

Paul continues instructing Timothy (1:3–11). He advises Timothy to use available resources, remain faithful, and learn from two poor examples. The church should expect Paul's delegate to do these things (the church is also part of the audience; see 1 Timothy Book Introduction, "Literary Genre").

1 Timothy 1:19

See also 1:5–6; 6:20–21; 2 Timothy 2:15–18. The conscience is like a guide inside a person (similar to a gyroscope, which helps something stay steady and on course). Keeping your conscience clear (or good) means protecting it so that it is not damaged or destroyed (see study note on 1 Timothy 4:2).

1 Timothy 1:20

- Hymenaeus and Alexander might have been leaders or elders in the church at Ephesus (see also 2 Timothy 2:17; 4:14; compare Acts 19:33; 20:29–31).
- The church was the area of the Holy Spirit's guidance. Paul allowed Hymenaeus and Alexander to be under Satan's influence (instead of the Holy Spirit's) by removing them from the church (see also 2 Timothy 2:25–26; Job 2:6; Matthew 18:17–20; 1 Corinthians 5:2–5; 2 Corinthians 2:5–11).
- Hymenaeus and Alexander blasphemed God by attacking the true good news, and thus God himself (see 1 Timothy 1:13; compare 6:1; Titus 2:5; 2 Peter 2:2).

1 Timothy 2:1

everyone: The prayers of the false teachers and their followers did not align with God's will to save all kinds of people (2:3–4).

1 Timothy 2:1–7

Here, prayer focuses on the church's mission. This suggests that false teachers damaged the church's reputation in society and hindered its mission to non-Jewish people (see 3:6–7; 6:1; Titus 2:5).

1 Timothy 2:1–15

This passage first covers prayer and then the behavior of men and women (2:1–7; 8–10). It ends with the topic of women and teaching (2:11–15).

1 Timothy 2:1–3.13

Paul addresses how false teachers influenced behavior in God's household, the church (3:15). Corruption had influenced worship, roles related to gender, and leadership within this community (2:1–15; 3:1–13).

1 Timothy 2:2

- all those in authority: These are people with the power to either persecute or protect the church (see also Romans 13:1–7; 1 Peter 2:13–17).
- lead tranquil and quiet lives: The goal is not that Christians hide. The goal is to show the beauty of the good news about Jesus through Christian living. It is also important to continue the church's mission without unnecessary problems (see 2 Timothy 3:12; 1 Peter 3:13–17).
- in all godliness: The word godliness and its related terms summarize the beliefs, attitudes, and lifestyles that align with true knowledge of God, obeying him, and genuine worship (also at 1 Timothy 3:16; 4:7–8; 5:4; 6:3, 5–6, 11).

1 Timothy 2:5

- There is one God and one mission for all people (Romans 3:29–30; Galatians 3:26–29). The phrase one God is a key statement of Christian faith, similar to the basics of Jewish faith (Deuteronomy 6:4).
- there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus: Jesus is fully human and fully God. This means he is the only one who can make peace between God and humanity (see 1 Corinthians 8:6; Ephesians 4:5–6).

1 Timothy 2:5–6

Short teachings like this one appear throughout the letters to Timothy and Titus (see also 1 Timothy 3:16; 2 Timothy 1:9–10; 2:8, 11–13; Titus 3:4–7). They might have adapted these teachings from creeds, hymns, or prayers familiar to the churches. The teachings probably relate to Paul's trouble with false teachers. The false teachers' teachings weakened the universal message of the good news about Jesus and the mission to non-Jews (Gentiles). The false teachers also did not accurately understand Jesus and his salvation.

1 Timothy 2:8

- Genuine prayer among the Ephesian church had declined because of the false teachers' influence (see 1 Timothy 6:4–5; 1:4; compare 2 Timothy 3:1–5; Titus 3:9–11).
- lifting up holy hands: See Isaiah 1:15–17. This was an ancient gesture for praise and asking for help (see Exodus 9:29; 1 Kings 8:22, 54; Nehemiah 8:6; Psalm 28:2; Luke 24:50).
- without anger or dissension: Compare James 3:8–12.

1 Timothy 2:9–10

- The subject is still community prayer.
- women to adorn themselves with respectable apparel, with modesty: Paul recommends Christian women must praise God rather than seek praise from people (compare 1 Peter 3:3–5). They should focus on doing good deeds for others, not on enhancing their appearance or being sexy. Gold, pearls, or expensive clothes suggest wealth (see 1 Timothy 6:5–10, 17–19). The reference to wealth might have been part of the power struggles within the church that Timothy had to address (2:11–15).

1 Timothy 2:11–15

Paul continues discussing women in the church, focusing on their role in public teaching (see also 1 Corinthians 11:2–16; 14:33–36; 2 Corinthians 11:3).

1 Timothy 2:12

- to teach or to exercise authority over a man: The link between teaching and authority depends on how we understand both. Women did teach (Titus 2:3–5). But the New Testament does not plainly show or support women teaching men in church meetings (see Acts 18:26; 1 Corinthians 14:34–35; Philippians 4:3). We know it happened in some churches because Paul responded against it. Women did prophesy (Acts 2:17–18; 21:9; 1 Corinthians 11:5). But some types of prophecy might not have been considered the same as teaching with authority (Acts 11:28; 21:10–11; 1 Corinthians 14:29).
- exercise authority over a man: This verb can mean either an attitude of dominance or simply exercising authority.

1 Timothy 2:13

- The common view of this verse is that Paul thinks social roles come from man being created first (Genesis 2:7, 22; 1 Corinthians 11:8–12). People often link Paul's reasoning to the leading role of the firstborn son in the Old Testament. However, there are exceptions to the firstborn rule in Scripture (see Genesis 27–28). While the New Testament retains gender differences, it also promotes equality in Christ (Galatians 3:28; see also 1 Corinthians 11:11–12; 12:13; Ephesians 5:21; Colossians 3:11).
- It is possible that some false teachers claimed a reversal of gender roles in Christ, which gave women a level of dominance to which Paul objected. Paul might be referring to this in order to challenge that claim and restore balance.

1 Timothy 2:15

Women, however, will be saved through childbearing (or by accepting their role as mothers, or by the birth

of the Child): The most likely explanation is that false teachers caused trouble in households (see 1 Timothy Book Introduction, "Setting"). Paul urged these women to return to proper roles in their homes, following the truth of the gospel (good news) (see 1:4–5; 4:1–5). By doing this, they would be saved in the ultimate sense (see 4:16; compare 3:13). This verse might refer to Genesis 3:15–16, suggesting a reversal of the effects of human sin. This could mean either the normal birth of children or the birth of the Messiah.

1 Timothy 3:1

- trustworthy saying: See study note on 1:15.
- an overseer: Some translations assume that overseer and church leader refer to the same role (see study note on 5:17–18; see Titus 1:5–7). In the Greek and Roman world, an overseer was a supervisor in religious, civic, or military contexts. The traditional translation of this term is "bishop" (see King James Version).

1 Timothy 3:1–13

The topic shifts to church leadership by overseers and deacons (3:1–7; 8–13). Timothy's role in the appointments is less plain than that of Titus (see 5:17–22; Titus 1:5). This may be because the church in Ephesus was more mature and better able to manage the process (see Acts 6:2–6).

The criteria listed here focus on character rather than function. It partly responds to the local false teachers and their followers. Reading this letter in the churches would make the criteria public and show that the false teachers were not qualified for leadership.

1 Timothy 3:2

- must be above reproach: This is a key requirement for a church leader and public representative (see 3:7, 10; 5:7; 6:14; Titus 1:6–7; 2:8).
- the husband of but one wife (or be married only once; literally be the husband of one wife; also in 1 Timothy 3:12): This suggests, but does not require, a married man. It focuses on pure character and loyalty in marriage. This was not always assumed in the surrounding culture. It probably does not forbid marrying again after a spouse's death and does not address polygamy specifically (literally, "marriage to many") (see 5:9). See also 3:12; Titus 1:6; compare 1 Timothy 5:9.
- hospitable (literally, "friend of the stranger"): This means to make a practice of hosting people in one's home. It was an important duty and virtue respected in ancient times. Traveling Christians would often stay with fellow Christians (see 2 John 1:10–11; 3 John). Additionally, first-century AD churches often met in private homes (see Colossians 4:15; Philemon 1:2).

1 Timothy 3:4–5

- The church, seen as a household, shared similarities with a family household (3:15). An overseer's ability to manage one area showed his skill in the other (see also 3:12; 5:17; Romans 12:8; 1 Thessalonians 5:12).
- Greek and Roman households were united by family bonds with shared responsibilities, roles, and management. The household included relatives by blood living together and other dependents, such as household servants.

1 Timothy 3:7

- Paul wanted Christians to live in a way that others outside the church could respect (see also 6:1; Titus 2:5–10).
- snare of the devil: might relate to the false teachers (see 1 Timothy 1:20; 5:14–15; 6:9; 2 Timothy 2:26).

1 Timothy 3:8

not ... greedy for money (3:3): Self-centered desire shows poor character (6:6–10, 17–19; Ephesians 5:3; Colossians 3:5). This is especially true for church leaders (1 Timothy 3:9; see Titus 1:7).

1 Timothy 3:8–13

The Greek word for deacon means "servant, assistant, messenger, or agent." Its related words mean "service" or "to serve" and often refer to any kind of service (for example, 4:6; Matthew 22:13; John 2:5; 12:26; Romans 13:4; 1 Corinthians 3:5). When plainly referring to a church office, it appears only in 1 Timothy 3:8–13; Philippians 1:1; and possibly Romans 16:1. Here the passage focuses on character rather than activities. See also study note on Acts 6:2–6.

1 Timothy 3:11

the women (or the women deacons, or their wives): The Greek word can mean women or wives. Supporting the interpretation of their wives, 3:8–13 discusses male deacons. Switching to "women deacons" here would change the context. However, there might have been women deacons in the early church (see Romans 16:1). If so, this verse might parallel 1 Timothy 3:8.

1 Timothy 3:14–4.16

This section explains how Timothy should spend his time until Paul arrives (3:14–15; 4:13).

1 Timothy 3:15

- God's household: The earliest churches were churches that met in homes (Romans 16:5; 1 Corinthians 16:19; Colossians 4:15; Philemon 1:2). They followed similar rules of behavior to Greek and Roman households (see study note on 1 Tim 3:4–5). Breaking the rules brought shame to the whole household and its leader. The same applies to the church (compare Ephesians 2:19–22; Hebrews 3:6; 10:21; 1 Peter 4:17).
- the pillar and foundation of the truth: This idea may be looking forward to the change from the time of the apostles to the period after their deaths (compare Galatians 2:9; Revelation 3:12). The church must be more active, not just defensive, to uphold the truth in the world (compare 2 Corinthians 10:3–6).

1 Timothy 3:16

- This verse contains a short song or statement of belief that emphasizes the profound religious teaching of early Christian worship.
- the mystery of godliness: Jesus Christ is the only source of godliness.
- vindicated by the Spirit: Christ's resurrection reframes the story as an act of power, following his human life and death. The resurrection confirms his teachings (Romans 1:4).
- seen by angels: This emphasizes Jesus's supreme rule in the realm of heaven (see also Ephesians 1:21; Philippians 2:9–11; Hebrews 1:3–4; 1 Peter 3:22; Revelation 5:8–14).
- proclaimed among the nations: The church must announce Christ's salvation and rule, and people on earth must accept it as well (compare 1 Timothy 2:1–7).
- believed in throughout the world: The mission to spread the message is successful, but not everyone will accept it.
- was taken up in glory: Christ went up to heaven, and God glorified him (Luke 24:51; Acts 1:2, 11, 22; compare Acts 7:55–56). Christ's work is successful on earth and glorified in heaven.

1 Timothy 4:1

later times: The early church believed it was already living in the later times (see Acts 2:16–17; Hebrews 1:2; compare 2 Thessalonians 2:7; 1 John 2:18–23).

1 Timothy 4:1–5

Paul's plain teaching contrasts with the false teachings he criticizes (3:16).

1 Timothy 4:2

whose consciences are seared with a hot iron: Dead consciences either do not work or work in harmful ways, making judgments that go against the truth of the good news about Jesus (see also Titus 1:15; Romans 1:28–32).

1 Timothy 4:6

- Brothers: The Greek word adelphoi refers to family members, both male and female.
- a good servant: Training good servants involves a complete pattern of behavior. Paul modeled this and based it on sound teachings. Good instruction unifies words and actions, beliefs and behaviors (see 3:10, 14–15; Philippians 4:9).

1 Timothy 4:6–16

Timothy needs to address the false teachers (see 2 Timothy 3:1–4:5).

1 Timothy 4:8–9

- physical exercise ... godliness: Compare with 1 Corinthians 9:24–27 and Colossians 2:23.
- holding promise for the present life and for the one to come: Compare with 1 Timothy 4:16, 6:6–8, Mark 10:29–30, and Ephesians 6:2–3.
- trustworthy saying: See study note on 1 Timothy 1:15.

1 Timothy 4:12

set an example: Only those whose lives are shaped by the good news about Jesus are worthy teachers of it (see 2 Timothy 3:10–11; Titus 2:7; Hebrews 13:7). The false teachers were not.

1 Timothy 4:14

the laying on of the hands: This gesture showed recognition, validity, and blessing (see Acts 13:1–3; 6:6). This was likely the same event as in 2 Timothy 1:6–7 (see 1 Timothy 1:18; compare Romans 12:6–8; 1 Corinthians 12:7–11; Ephesians 4:7–13). This is the way the church validated Paul's ministry and that of his delegates.

1 Timothy 5:1–6.2

Proper behavior in God's spiritual household involves everyone, including:

- the old and young (5:1–2),
- widows (5:3–16),

- old people (5:17–25), and
- slaves (6:1–2a).

Showing respect within the household goes beyond social boundaries.

1 Timothy 5:3–16

A widow without wealth or family was alone in a world that did not support her. The Christian community was expected to care for such widows among its members (see Deuteronomy 10:17–19; Isaiah 1:17; compare Acts 6:1–6; James 1:27). Some suggest this passage implies a religious order of widows in the first-century AD church at Ephesus. However, there is no obvious evidence of such an order, only of a ministry to help community members without financial means.

1 Timothy 5:5

The widow who is truly in need and left all alone: Women in this situation could only rely on their hope in God (Psalms 68:5; 146:9).

1 Timothy 5:6

but she who lives for pleasure: Some widows in Ephesus lived only for pleasure. They cared more about receiving than giving to others (see also 6:17–19; James 5:5). They did not need support.

1 Timothy 5:8

The faith of the Christians was and is more than just belief. It is a complete way of living (see James 2:14–26).

1 Timothy 5:9

- at least sixty: Young widows needed a different approach (5:11–15). People were usually divided between young and old at around forty. Elderly people were probably those over fifty (see Titus 2:2).
- the wife of one man: The grammar is the same in 1 Timothy 3:2, 12; Titus 1:6.

1 Timothy 5:10

washing the feet of the saints: See Genesis 18:4; Luke 7:44; John 13:1–17.

1 Timothy 5:11–12

their first faith: If Paul was concerned about a second marriage to non-Christians, this phrase might refer to their Christian faith (see 5:14). They would give up this faith by entering a marriage with a pagan (worshiper of false gods). This would probably separate them from Christ. It is also possible that Paul and the church recognized a special category of "sacred widowhood" (see 5:5; compare Acts 9:36–37). These widows entered this category by making a vow.

1 Timothy 5:11–15

Younger widows who could still have children needed a different approach. Paul worried that false teachers were leading them into error.

1 Timothy 5:13

- Those fully supported by the church rarely dedicate their lives to a true commitment (see 2:9–10; 5:10). Abusing the church's support harms both them and the gospel (good news) (see 5:14).
- discussing things they should not mention: This suggests involvement in false teachings (5:15; see 2 Thessalonians 3:11–13; Titus 1:11).

1 Timothy 5:14

- Paul advises younger widows to marry again and to marry Christians (5:11–12; see also 2:15).
- denying the adversary occasion for slander: Their actions were harming their testimony for the good news about Jesus (see 1 Thessalonians 4:11–12; Titus 2:8).

1 Timothy 5:15

already turned aside to follow Satan: They had turned away from Christ, probably because of false teachers and how they indulge themselves (1:6–7; compare 3:6–7; Hebrews 2:1; 1 Timothy 5:6, 13).

1 Timothy 5:16

Individual Christian households kept their roles and identities within the church (see 2:15; 3:15). The church did not control them. However, the household of God is central to the identity of the Christian community (see Mark 3:31–35).

1 Timothy 5:17–18

are worthy of double honor: Compare Galatians 6:6. There is no evidence of paid leadership at this time. The word used here never refers to a continuous salary. But it does imply more than just respect. The quotations from Scripture suggest gifts of money (Deuteronomy 25:4; Luke 10:7).

1 Timothy 5:17–25

Elders: In Judaism, community leaders were usually older men who led the wider community. The letters to Timothy acknowledge an office of elders (Greek presbuteroi) called "overseers" (see also 3:1–7). Titus

lists both offices (Titus 1:5–9). But the term also refers to older men in the community (as in 1 Timothy 4:14; Titus 1:5; 1 Timothy 5:1).

1 Timothy 5:19–21

- The false teachers may have caused false accusations against Christian leaders. This passage follows the outline of Deuteronomy 19:15–21.
- two or three witnesses: See Deuteronomy 17:6; 19:15; Matthew 18:16; 2 Corinthians 13:1; Hebrews 10:28.

1 Timothy 5:20

- Those who persist in sin: This refers to someone accused, whether the accusation is true or false (Deuteronomy 19:16–19).
- the others: This could mean the other elders or the rest of the church (compare Deuteronomy 19:20; Acts 5:1–11).

1 Timothy 5:21

- God and Christ Jesus and the elect angels serve as three witnesses (5:19). These witnesses confirm accusations against leaders who sin (5:20).
- Angels represent a connection to God's judgment (Daniel 7:9–10; Matthew 13:49; 25:31, 41; Luke 9:26; 2 Thessalonians 1:7).

1 Timothy 5:22

Do not ... share in the sins of others: Those who ordain or appoint an elder are accountable for his actions.

1 Timothy 5:23

The concern with being pure might have been excessive regarding wine or food (5:22; see 3:3; Numbers 6:1–21; 1 Corinthians 10:21). People may have considered wine as medicine.

1 Timothy 5:24–25

These two wise sayings summarize 5:17–23 and emphasize God's judgment.

1 Timothy 6:1

Paul recommends that those who are slaves should treat both non-Christian and Christian masters with respect. This practice will honor God's name and give a good reputation to Christian teaching (see study note on 5:1–6:2).

1 Timothy 6:2–10

This paragraph reveals that the true desire of false teachers is wealth, not God.

1 Timothy 6:2–21

The final major part of the letter focuses on Timothy's need to challenge the false teachers. This section mirrors the structure of 1:3–20.

1 Timothy 6:4

he has an unhealthy interest in controversies and semantics: It is the same problem as in 1:4 (see also 2 Timothy 2:23–24; Titus 3:9).

1 Timothy 6:5

- who are devoid of the truth: Literally have been robbed of the truth; see 2 Timothy 2:18; 3:7, 8; 4:4; Titus 1:14.
- regard godliness as a means of gain: (see 1 Timothy 2:2; 3:8; 4:8; 6:3; see also 2 Timothy 3:2; Acts 8:9–25): It is uncertain how these false teachers thought they would profit. In the broader culture, many traveling teachers earned money through teaching. Abuse of this system was common, and people often accused them of teaching for "gain and glory." Perhaps the false teachers in 1 Timothy brought this practice into the church or promoted a gospel marked by wealth or success. They seem to have influenced wealthy Christians and possibly women in particular (1 Timothy 6:17–19; 2:9; 5:6).

1 Timothy 6:6

with contentment: This is not only a philosophical view but also a true reliance on Christ as all-sufficient. See 4:8; 2 Corinthians 9:8; 12:7–10; Philippians 4:10–13; Hebrews 13:5.

1 Timothy 6:11–16

Before ending the discussion on wealth, Paul urges Timothy to live an innocent life. Paul encourages Timothy to flee the desire for wealth.

1 Timothy 6:12

- The promise of eternal life reduces the attraction of wealth (see 6:19).
- Paul probably refers to when Timothy confessed his faith during baptism.

1 Timothy 6:13

Paul emphasizes the historical aspect of Christ's role as a mediator (see 2:5–6). Paul holds up the way Christ Jesus testified during his trial before Pontius Pilate to set an example for Timothy to remain strong under pressure (Matthew 27:11–14; Luke 23:1–4; John 18:33–38; 19:9–11).

1 Timothy 6:14

until the appearance of our Lord Jesus Christ: The letters to Timothy and Titus describe Christ's comings, both past and future, as "epiphanies" or "appearances" (2 Timothy 1:10; Titus 2:11; 2 Timothy 4:1, 8; Titus 2:13). An epiphany is a divine intervention at a specific historical moment. The church exists between these past and future appearances of Christ.

Christ's first saving epiphany allowed for a new life. His future epiphany will bring final salvation. Although the present is evil, our anticipation of Christ's appearance encourages us to live a life pleasing to God now (the "later times," 1 Timothy 4:1–3; 2 Timothy 3:1–9). False teachers allowed sinful behaviors because they believed the resurrection had already happened (2 Timothy 2:18). Paul clarifies that salvation has started but is not yet complete. Being part of God's household requires responsible conduct in the light of Christ's past, present, and future saving work (1 Timothy 3:15–16; Titus 2:11–14).

1 Timothy 6:15–16

- in his own time: At the right time, God will complete the salvation promised to us before the world began (compare 2:6); 2 Timothy 1:9; Titus 1:2). Christ began this salvation in his first appearance (1 Timothy 2:6; Titus 1:3). Christ's work of salvation fits within God's eternal plans. This knowledge naturally leads to worshiping God who saves us (see 1 Timothy 1:17).
- This prayer might come from a confession saying for use at baptisms (see study note on 6:12).

1 Timothy 6:17–18

for us to enjoy: Christian hope encourages us to manage resources responsibly (Genesis 1:28–30; 2:15). We should use our resources for enjoyment and to share Christ's love with others (see 1 Timothy 4:3–5; Psalm 145:16; Acts 14:17; see Luke 12:16–34; 2 Corinthians 8:1–9:15).

1 Timothy 6:17–19

According to 6:11–16, it is unwise to value the temporary wealth of this age (James 5:3). It is wiser to gather treasure for the future age by trusting in God, doing good deeds, and showing generosity and love to others (see 1 Timothy 1:5).

1 Timothy 6:20

what has been entrusted to you (literally the deposit): The good news about Jesus is a deposit given to the church and its leaders to keep safe (1:15; 2:5–6; 3:16). It includes an entire way of life (2 Timothy 1:13–14; 3:10–11). It strengthens and cleanses the church when confronted with false teachings in challenging times (2 Timothy 3:1). The deposit is part of the church's tradition (see 2 Timothy 2:2; 1 Corinthians 11:23–25; 15:1–8; 2 Thessalonians 2:15; 3:6). It needs creative and true interpretation to address changing situations and problems (see 2 Timothy 1:12–14).

1 Timothy 6:20–21

This short but pointed message emphasizes how important Timothy's task is in Ephesus (see 1:18–20; 2 Timothy 1:13–14).

1 Timothy 6:21

- The letter ends suddenly. There was no need for mission directions (see Titus 3:12–14). Greetings were either not necessary or not appropriate (see Titus 3:15; Romans 16:3–16).
- you all: Paul sent the letter to Timothy. But Paul meant it to be read to the entire church (see 1 Timothy Book Introduction, "Literary Genre").